

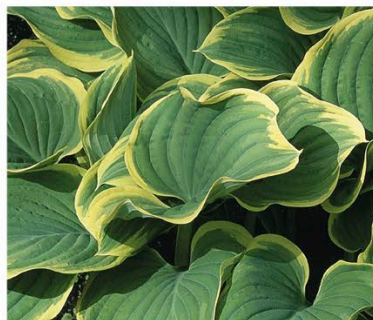


Plant focus: hostas

Invaluable in cool shady sites, the dramatic, sculptural leaves of hostas add color and texture to many areas of the garden.

THEIR DRAMATIC FOLIAGE and love of cool damp conditions make hostas popular plants for shady sites. Plant them as ground cover at the edge of tree canopies, include them in a bog garden beside a pond, or use colorful forms to create architectural container displays. Most hostas are knee-high, although taller and dwarf forms are also available, and they are grown for their dramatic blue, golden, or green leaves, which can be a solid color or variegated. The foliage is joined in summer by tall spires of lilylike, often fragrant, flowers. Although fairly undemanding and tolerant of periods of drought, all hostas suffer to some degree from slug and snail damage, with thin-leaved forms being the worst affected. To prevent shredded foliage, protect plants by covering tender new growth with grit and sand, or surround mature plants with copper rings. Also, look for slug-resistant cultivars, such as 'Krossa Regal', 'Great Expectations', 'Halcyon', and 'Big Daddy'.

POPULAR HOSTA FORMS



Large-leaved hostas With leaves growing up to 16in (40cm) long, popular choices include 'Sagae' and 'Sum and Substance'.



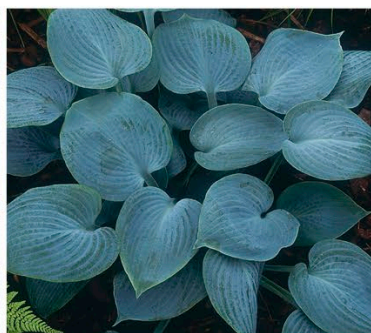
Dwarf forms Less than 18in (45cm) in height, dwarf hostas include *H. venusta*, *H. 'Dorset Blue'*, 'Hadsphen Heron', and 'Pilgrim'.



Variegated forms Large or small, these colorful and variable plants feature white or golden margins, or pale or darker central markings.



Golden-leaved forms Requiring some sunlight, the golden-leaved forms include a range of plant sizes and foliage shapes. Popular forms include 'Yellow River', 'Yellow Splash', 'Piedmont Gold', 'Golden Prayers', 'Gold Drop', 'Fortunei Aureomarginata', and 'Fortunei Albopicta'.



Blue-leaved forms Grown for its blue, textured foliage, this group ranges from the large-leaved 'Blue Angel' to the dainty 'Blue Moon'.

